

the premium of a medical cover changes as we age. You need to look at two things in price. How does the price compare with policies from other companies right now and how does the price compare over the years? Your policy may cost the least today but may become the most expensive when you hit age sixty or seventy.

If you are buying from an agent, ask him to show you the price comparison at ten-year differences. If you are forty, ask for the price of the policy as it is today when sold to a fifty-, sixty- and seventy-year-old. If he can't do the work, find another agent. He will be getting a commission on your purchase now and every year after you buy. Let him earn this commission by doing the work that you want him to do. Don't get distracted by the sales spiel.

Benefits

We buy a medical cover so that when faced with a hospital bill we don't have to dip into our savings. The deal is simple: You pay an annual premium and when you get hospitalized, the insurance company pays the bill. But then it is a complicated world. Insurance companies have the ability to set up the game so that you lose. And given how technical an insurance product is, there is no way you will know all that there is to know. You need to find out if your policy gives at least these eight benefits.

One, ***ensure that you have a policy that does not have something called a 'co-pay' clause***. This is called 'co-pay' because you agree to pay a certain percentage of a bill to share the costs with the insurance company. Unfair, you exclaim. It is, except when a senior citizen goes to buy a cover, co-pay allows him to at least get a cover. More of that later. For example, if you agree to a co-pay of 10 per cent, you have agreed to pick up one-tenth of the cost of the hospitalization. If your bill is Rs 2 lakhs, you will have to pay Rs 20,000 and the insurance company will pay 90 per cent or Rs 1.8 lakhs.

Look for a policy that does not have a co-pay clause. Ask your agent to mail you the policy document and then do a search on the words co-pay. Search the net to see if the policy being sold has complaints related to it having a co-pay clause. Build an email trail with the company or the agent to ensure that you